Collaboration and Outreach in the Digital Scholarship Center: Lessons Learned from UChicago's Library and Emerging Technologies Summer Camp

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Introduction

The University of Chicago's Center for Digital Scholarship opened the doors to its space in the Joseph Regenstein Library in April 2024 after five years of planning, construction, and hiring. Though now physically embedded in the Library, many of the Center's intra-institutional connections were still inconsistent and ephemeral. Much of this stemmed from the ambiguity of the term "Digital Scholarship" and the existence of other units on campus with similar sounding names, services, or missions.

As the Center was able to boast a full staff for the first time since its conception in 2019, our team sought to find a way to establish the Center for Digital Scholarship as a resource for students and faculty as well as a thought partner and collaborator with other divisions of the Library. While many were excited about having newly staffed positions such as a GIS Librarian, Digital Scholarship Librarian, and Head of Research Data Management, a sense of confusion persisted among Library staff about when to direct patrons to the Center and what projects Center staff could help with.

Context

The concept of a Digital Scholarship and Digital Humanities summer program is not new. Many institutions have organized successful programs surrounding digital methods (Iantorno, 2014). The Digital Humanities Summer Institute at the Université de Montréal, for example, has been around since 2001 (Siemens et al, 2023). In that 24-year history, many similar boot camp-style programs have emerged such as the University of Pennsylvania's Dream Lab and the Digital Humanities at Oxford Summer School . From 2008 on, interested scholars also had an opportunity to learn about DH through various THAT (The Humanities and Technology) Camps organized around the globe, which used the model of the "unconference" for community skill-sharing (Cohen, 2020; THATCamp).

Outside of these events and conferences, institutions have created their own internal programs aimed at training faculty and staff on new digital tools. Barnard College's Thinking Digitally Institute, an instructor-focused institute focusing on incorporating digital projects into syllabi (Jones-Davidis, 2020), and Columbia University's Developing Librarian Project, a two-year librarian-focused program (Bakkalbasi et al, 2015: 210), are both examples of this targeted approach.

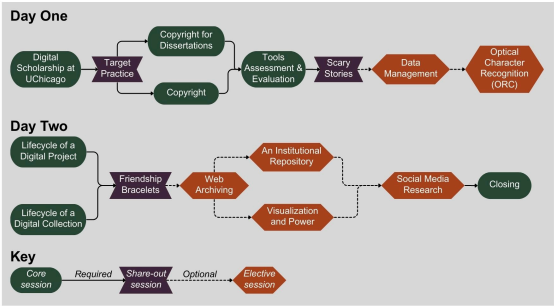

Figure 1. Comparison of three Digital Humanities programs

The UChicago Center for Digital Scholarship wanted to create a program that combined the best of both approaches. We hoped to create a tailored program for librarians that fostered an environment of exploration, creativity, and fun. Paying attention to the offerings at the Thinking Digitally Institute, the Developing Librarian Program, and Michigan State University's iteration of THAT Camp (Evjen, 2024), we began the planning for UChicago's first Library and Emerging Technologies Summer Camp (LETS Camp).

Approach

LETS Camp offered six core sessions covering topics essential to the Center's offerings. These included Digital Scholarship at UChicago, Introduction to Copyright and Copyright for Dissertations (offered simultaneously), Lifecycle of a Digital Project and Lifecycle of a Digital Collection (offered simultaneously), and Tools Assessment and Evaluation. In addition to the core classes, attendees had the option to participate in six elective sessions, including Data Management, Optical Character Recognition (OCR), Web Archiving, Institutional Repositories, Visualization and Power, and Social Media Research. These electives were meant as a space for deeper exploration of topics that may be relevant to only a subset of participants.

Outside of formal workshops, all LETS Camp participants joined in four discussion-based sessions that provided a space for librarians to share collaboration opportunities, fears and frustrations around emerging technologies, and goals for the program and coming academic year. These "share-out" sessions were included to build community and trust between established Library departments and the Center. It was our hope that, in including opportunities for dialogue, participants could feel that they, too, played an active role in defining what Digital Scholarship means at the Library.

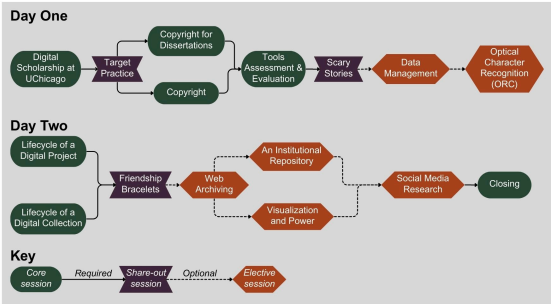

Figure 2. Diagram of sessions offered during LETS Camp 2024

Reflection

During our closing session, we asked participants to share their perspectives on the programming and were met with largely positive responses. Attendees mentioned that they were grateful to have an opportunity to speak with Library staff that they do not often interact with and that the event opened up opportunities for collaboration they hadn't thought of before. Participants generally agreed that they felt they understood what the CDS offered much better after the program.

One major challenge of holding a digital scholarship training series aimed at any library employee was the need to accommodate many different skill levels. Workshops on topics such as OCR had to account for total beginners as well as those interested in using Python for OCR. Because of this, workshops were designed to start conversations rather than provide comprehensive training. Participants flagged the lack of technical instruction as an area for improvement for subsequent programs. This feedback has been instrumental in the planning process for CDS offerings throughout the school year.

The Center team has already begun planning for LETS Camp 2025. After discussions with participants and among our staff, we have decided to alternate our approach bi-annually, offering a traditional LETS Camp every other year and a modified version on the off years. Our alternative LETS Camp, *LETS Day Camp*, will offer programming over the span of a month rather than consecutive programming over two full workdays. We wanted to make LETS Camp more accessible to Library

support staff, who were not able to dedicate full workdays to professional development.

Future iterations of this event may also engage with the Library's new commitment to wider accessibility of its services and greater community engagement by opening up enrollment opportunities for public librarians and educators from around the South Side community (The University of Chicago Library). While we are not exploring this for LETS Camp 2025, we are in the midst of creating a repository of instructional materials from LETS Camp and other Center workshops that can be adapted to meet the needs of a broader audience. It is our hope that, through building up our instructional resources and capacity, we will be able to offer programming with a wider impact in the coming years.

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